

HOW TO FINISH STRONG

I want to begin tonight with a trivia question:
Which building project took the longest to complete?

1). The construction of the Pentagon. Finished January 16, 1943 – 6,500,000 Square Feet.

(Place a picture of the Pentagon on the screen)

2. The carving of Mount Rushmore. Completed October 31, 1941. **(Place a picture of Mt. Rushmore on the screen)**

3. The digging of the Panama Canal. Completed August 15, 1914. **(Place a picture of the Panama Canal on the screen)**

4. The building of the Empire State Building. The construction of this mammoth building (2,768,591 Square Feet) was completed on May 1, 1931 **(Place a picture of the Empire State Building on the screen)**

5. The carving and assembling of the Statue of

Liberty. This structure is 305 feet tall and was completed on October 28, 1886. **(Place a picture of the Statue of Liberty on the Screen)**

The answer is number 3. It took 31 years to dig the Panama Canal, mainly because that superhuman task was started and stopped several times due to floods, mudslides, unexpected costs (the total bill for the United States was \$375 million in 1914). The project carried a horrific death toll as well (20,000 French workers and 6,000 Americans died on the job site.) The moral of that story: Expect delays, and more than expected expenses, when you cut a 50-mile-long canal to connect two oceans.

So, what do these five projects have in common? Despite the cost overruns, delays, and the personal anguish, they were all eventually finished!

Tonight, I want to talk to us about finishing what we have started. I mean after all, we told everyone *“The Lord told us to do this!”*

If you are walking in your purpose you are attempting to do something that may feel overwhelming, and at times impossible. If we can do it on our own, it is not a God dream. All God dreams require faith, and an enormous amount of persistence.

The good news is that God calls each of us to join Him in HIS work, which we gladly, and anxiously respond with a great big YES! The trouble is, that we often create our own plans and ask God to join us in what we are doing. At the same time, He is patiently waiting for us to get on His page. (Staff member who said, *“If you and I could ever get on the same page, we could do something great!”*)

Accomplishing anything spiritual such as

- Building a church
- Winning the lost

- Influencing culture for Christ

...is impossible in human terms.

We can't accomplish anything for God without supernatural faith, and we will certainly never be able to finish the task at hand without His help, and the help of a host of others.

God gives us a promise—that's the easy part. Then He:

- Reveals His strategies
- Works His miracles
- Sends His provision

Working with God is exhilarating when these things happen. If I were to tell my story of Kingdom service over the last 50 years, we would be here the rest of the night. (Turtle on a stump)

All Kingdom assignments require faith, but operating in faith is also warfare. If we intend to do Kingdom work, we must come dressed and

armed for war!

The devil hurls doubts and obstacles in our direction. He sends people who will sling insults. He does his best to raise the cost of doing Kingdom business. There are battles and, sometimes, casualties. These are the times we are tempted to quit. If you have never been tempted to quit, I suggest that you have never started!

To talk about finishing what we have started, I want to look at the overlooked book of Haggai. In the book of Haggai, the people had just returned from 70 years of Babylonian captivity with the dream of rebuilding the land as well as the Temple. As with all of us who have ever attempted to accomplish a goal, everything started off fast and furious, with tons of excitement and plenty of help.

But inside arguing and turmoil, as well as neighboring nations hurling insults and making threats, the work had come to a screeching halt.

Not only did the work cease, it remained in a dormant state, for sixteen years. Think of this, the TEMPLE, half built, sitting there, incomplete, and in a state of decay for sixteen years! (Think of a construction project sitting unfinished for 16 years – Since 2007)

The book of Haggai was written, all two chapters and thirty-eight verses, to Zerubbabel and Joshua, the two men commissioned to rebuild Solomon's temple.

These men had no doubt struggled with intense discouragement as they looked at the ruins of Jerusalem, and a half-built Temple:

- The task was overwhelming
- The cost was prohibitive
- The workers were in a state of confusion
- Their enemies were fierce

They started the work in earnest, but they heard a familiar voice that whispered: *“You’ll never finish this. God is going to abandon you in the*

middle of this project. ” Sometimes we allow the words of the enemy to become louder than the command of the assignment. Every Kingdom assignment comes prepackaged with a Sanballat and Tobiah.

At this juncture, the Prophet Haggai steps onto the scene. God always has a man or woman of God, who will speak life into a failing assignment!

The Prophet Haggai says four things that I feel I must speak into someone's life and assignment tonight:

BE BRAVE

Think of this, these people have suffered Babylonian captivity and have been back in Judah for almost twenty years! They sit paralyzed by their past and present circumstances, staring at a city that is still a disaster from a war almost a century prior. And the Prophet Haggai steps onto the scene and says “***Be brave!***”

Fear of failure has kept these people from moving forward for sixteen years! How long have we been idling in neutral, staring at the work in front of us because we are bound by fear? (Talk about fear being the constant companion of those who operate in great faith)

God never responds to fear or desperation, he only responds to faith. (365 times the Bible says ***“Fear not!”***)

Whatever your Kingdom assignment may be, I am speaking into your spirit tonight, ***“Be brave!”***

DO THE WORK

The scene in front of these people was no doubt overwhelming, but the one thing that had to be stopped, before the assignment could be completed, was idleness! The Prophet Haggai stepped onto the scene and announced a season of Work! God wasn't going to come down from Heaven and wave a magic wand! The people were going to have to complete the work!

The one thing that had to be started before anything would change was to initiate the discipline of work! Nothing will ever be completed without our committing to be disciplined in our work ethic.

If we are going to accomplish Kingdom assignments, we must come dressed for work! What is the dress code for Kingdom workers? It is the whole armor of God! This is not only work it is war!

- Belt of truth
- Breastplate of righteousness
- Shoes of the gospel of peace
- Shield of faith
- Helmet of salvation
- Sword of the Spirit
- Constant prayer and supplication

(Nehemiah – A weapon and a hammer!)

I AM WITH YOU

Because of the sins of their ancestors, these

people had experienced slavery at its worst. Following their captivity, they experienced a season of hope, as they returned to their homeland and set about the work of rebuilding the Temple and the city.

Then, through internal strife, and external threats, they had experienced almost twenty years of paralysis. Does this sound familiar? (I got terribly discouraged building my house in Arkansas)

Think of how we would feel if this were our plight in life. What if we were staring at a project that had languished in an unfinished state for sixteen years, and someone shows up next Sunday and preached a whole sermon on how *“The Lord is with you!”*

In Judges six, Gideon and his family had experienced twenty years of losing to their enemies. The Lord showed up and said to him, ***“I am with you, you mighty man of valor.”*** (At this point he was hiding in the winepress

threshing wheat – Hiding from the enemy – He had never fought a battle – Except for playing Cowboys and Midianites in his head)

I think maybe the thoughts running through the heads of the people of Judah regarding the words of Haggai, were probably the same thoughts that Gideon had. ***“If the Lord is with us, then why has all of this befallen us?”***

Even though there was little evidence, it was nonetheless true - ***“The Lord was with them.”***

Someone needs to hear this tonight – ***“The Lord is with you.”***

FINISH IT

Fortunately, just when Zerubbabel and Joshua were about to throw in the towel, the prophet Haggai showed up with a refreshing announcement. He told them... Haggai 2:4 (NASB) ***“‘But now take courage ... and work; for I am with you,’ declares the Lord”***

The Lord also promised He would see the

building project to completion. He said...

Haggai 2:9 (NASB) ***“The latter glory of this house will be greater than the former ... and in this place I will give peace”***

Those powerful prophetic promises propelled Zerubbabel and Joshua forward. These words were just what the doctor ordered to invigorate their faith and still their determination. Their passion was refueled. They returned to the work, even though it seemed impossible. In the end, God’s glorious house arose from an ash heap.

This is God’s promise to all who are called to labor with Him. He does not tell you to begin something and then leave you halfway through it. God is a wise builder and an expert craftsman. He is the Alpha and Omega, the beginning and the end. He finishes what He starts.

The apostle Paul knew this when he wrote...

Philippians 1:6 ***“For I am confident of this very***

thing, that He who began a good work in you will perfect it until the day of Christ Jesus”

The Message Bible says it this way... *“There has never been the slightest doubt in my mind that the God who started this great work in you, would keep at it and bring it to a flourishing finish on the very day Christ Jesus appears.”*

CONCLUSION:

Many Kingdom Builders are bone tired of staring at an unfinished project:

- Budgets are probably tight
- Resistance from the enemy is strong
- The trends look negative
- The devil is busy trying to abort God’s promises (His agenda is more about aborting God’s plan than defeating us)

Because of these things you may have been tempted to abandon your Kingdom Assignment.

But I want to encourage us with the words of Haggai:

- Be brave...
- Do the work
- He is with you
- Finish the work